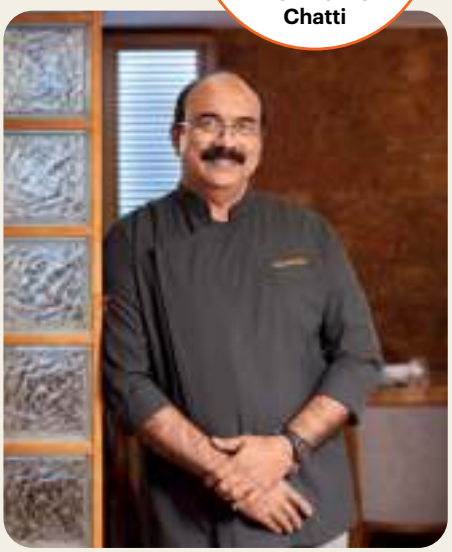
CHAD SANTO TOMAS



MASTER CREATORS Top, Srijith Gopinathan of Ettan and Eylan; Regi Matthew of New York's Chatti



ALEX STANILOFF

BENGALURU'S CELEBRATED 100-YEAR-OLD **MAVALLI TIFFIN ROOMS (MTR)** BROUGHT KARNATAKA-STYLE FOOD TO BELLEVUE SHINGTON, IN 2

Indian chefs internationally have taken the global spotlight off butter chicken and naan as representative of Indian food, and have rewritten the narrative that the cuisine is only about hitting high notes on the Scoville scale. In the US, South Indian food rules. In 2014, Rasa opened in California, soon winning a Michelin star for its contemporary take on South Indian food, focused on coastal cuisines. It succumbed to the pressures of Covid-19 in 2022, but was resurrected on popular demand in 2024. Godavari, with a focus on Andhra and Telangana food, opened in Boston in 2015, expanding to 22 outlets today in the US alone. Chef Vijay Kumar's Semma opened in New York in 2021 and earned its Michelin star in 2022. Nathai Pirattal (stir-fried snails with mini Kal Dosas) and Chettinad Maan (venison) are among the top sellers here.

Thattu, in Chicago, specialises in Kerala cuisine and grew from a pop-up to a full-fledged restaurant from 2018 to 2023. And then there is Srijith Gopinathan, executive chef and co-owner of Ettan, Eylan, Little Blue Door and Copra, the last being a tribute to his South Indian roots, in San Francisco. He pioneered the Cal-Indian approach—California's seasonal ingredients meet South Indian spices, masalas and techniques. At Copra, a Meen Polichathu is made with black cod. The Winter Vegetable Masala Uthappam has Swiss chard, squash and heirloom carrots.

Chef Srijith attributes the US's growing interest in Indian regional food to several factors. First, the burgeoning Indian population (5.4 million as of June 2024 according to Statistica), has significant spending power. "Indian restaurants initially began out of necessity, by business folk coming in and not finding their cuisine. Today, educated chefs, proud of their ethnicity, are showcasing their food in the US. Restaurants are no longer mom-and-pop set-ups and Indian investors have the money to support such spaces. It is the perfect storm situation for Indian food," he says.

This perfect storm has been ideal for a venture like Chatti by Regi Mathew which opened in New York this February. Founder-partner Chef Regi Mathew is renowned for his India-based Kappa Chakka Kandhari, which, in his words, focuses on the nostalgia of a mother's cooking. Chatti, however, showcases Kerala's toddy shop culture—'touchings' (slang for bar snacks) included. This Kerala culinary experience has been reimagined for the US.

"The toddy shop experience is about food, drink and conversation, and I felt this concept was a great way to reach out to the global market. Besides Malayalis, our South Indian clientele are proud of the cuisine and concept, and bring in native New Yorkers to show them what a taste of their Indian hometown is like. When an Indian in the US takes you to an Indian restaurant, you know that the food will be good," says Chef Regi.

And the toddy shop culture comes to life with local produce. Pomfret, king prawns, lobster and scallops are grilled with Chef Regi's signature